

A Treatise on Differential Equations of the Ordinary Kind

With Notes on Integration

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0 Another Try at Nets

1 Compactness

We will now discuss the equivalence of topological and sequential compactness in the reals and in general metric spaces. Let us view the following theorem:

1.1 Limit Points

The limits of sequences ARE NOT necessarily limit points. Given some subset $E \subseteq \mathbb{R}$, x is a limit point of E if:

$$\forall \epsilon > 0 : B(x, \epsilon) \cap E \neq \emptyset$$

Notice how this only requires the intersection to be nonempty; which means there could possibly be a finite number of points in the intersection (but we will see this is not possible). Let us look at the following lemma:

Lemma 1.1. *x is a limit point of E if and only if*

$$\exists \{x_n\}_{n \in \mathbb{N}} \in (E \setminus \{x\})^{\mathbb{N}} : x_n \rightarrow x$$

Proof. $\implies$: If x is a limit point, then using the first countability of metric spaces, consider:

$$\epsilon_n := \frac{1}{n+1}$$

Then by axiom of choice, choose $x_n \in B(x, \epsilon_n) \cap E \setminus \{x\}$, so that:

$$\forall n \in \mathbb{N} : |x_n - x| < \frac{1}{n+1} \implies x_n \rightarrow x$$

$\impliedby$: Now for the converse. If there exists such a sequence $\{x_n\}_{n \in \mathbb{N}}$ such that:

$$\forall \epsilon > 0, \exists n_0 \geq 0, \forall n \geq n_0 : |x_n - x| < \epsilon$$

then we see that

$$\forall \epsilon > 0 : B(x, \epsilon) \cap E \setminus \{x\} \neq \emptyset$$

as $\forall n \geq n_0 : x_n \in B(x, \epsilon)$ and by definition of the sequence $x_n \in E \setminus \{x\}$. Thus proving equivalence. $\square$

Now we introduce the following notion:

Definition 1.1. *An ω -limit point of a set E is one for which there exists a countably infinite number of points of E within each punctured ϵ -ball around x .*

It follows that every limit point in $\mathbb{R}$ is an ω -limit point from Lemma 1.1, the sequential definition. This is because:

$$\forall \epsilon > 0, \exists n_0 \geq 0, \forall n \geq n_0 : x_n \in B(x, \epsilon) \cap E \setminus \{x\}$$

and the natural numbers n_0 and beyond are countably infinite (an injection of $\mathbb{N}$ into this set can easily be shown), thus x is an ω -accumulation point. The weakest sufficient condition is a T_1 space for such equivalence.

Observe the definition of sequential closure of some subset E :

Definition 1.2. $\overline{E}$ is the closure of E if and only if

$$\forall \{x_n\}_{n \in \mathbb{N}} \in E^{\mathbb{N}} : x_n \rightarrow x \implies x \in \overline{E}$$

So by the equivalence stated in Lemma 1.1, $\{x_n\}_{n \in \mathbb{N}}$ belongs to $E^{\mathbb{N}}$ as well (it is not guaranteed that $x \in E$), but by sequential closure x or the limit point must belong in $\overline{E}$.

Now steering our attention back to sequences, the limit of a sequence may not be a limit point. Consider an eventually constant or constant sequence. We see that it converges to whatever value it is eventually constant at; but there is an empty ϵ -punctured ball intersection. So a limit point is a limit of a specific type of sequence, but not vice versa.

This distinction will be quite crucial in the following section.

1.2 Sequential Compactness

Theorem 1.1 (Sequential Bolzano Weierstrass). *Any bounded sequence has a convergent subsequence.*

To prove this fact, we show first that any sequence in $\mathbb{R}$ has a monotonic subsequence.

Proof. Let us define the following set, we call "peaks" of a sequence:

$$P := \{n \in \mathbb{N} : (\forall j > n : x_j < x_n)\}$$

In the case that P is countably infinite, then we set:

$$n_0 := \inf P \wedge \forall k > 0 : n_k := \inf (P \setminus \{n_0, \dots, n_{k-1}\})$$

In which case we are guaranteed that $\forall k \in \mathbb{N} : n_{k+1} > n_k$ which tells us that $x_{n_{k+1}} < x_{n_k}$, showing that there exists a strictly decreasing subsequence. In the case that P is finite, we choose the following:

$$n_0 := \sup(P) + 1$$

that way the peaks are fully omitted from the subsequence, as they will prove to be problematic in the construction. Then for any $k \in \mathbb{N}$, we are guaranteed that $n_k \notin P$ (since $\{n_k\}_{k \in \mathbb{N}}$ is strictly increasing and $n_0 \notin P$), which means:

$$\exists j > n_k : x_j \geq x_{n_k}$$

So we simply define:

$$\forall k \in \mathbb{N} : n_{k+1} := \inf \{j > n_k : x_j \geq x_{n_k}\}$$

in which case we obtain a non-decreasing subsequence. Now any bounded sequence has a monotone subsequence, which converges. What this means is given some sequence $\{x_n\}_{n \in \mathbb{N}}$, we have that:

$$\exists y \in \mathbb{R}, \exists r > 0, \forall n \in \mathbb{N} : x_n \in B(y, r)$$

so the sequence has a convergent subsequence within the ball, but such a subsequence may not converge within the ball. This is due to the topological idea that the limit point certainly belongs in the closure of the set but not necessarily in the open set. Consider the bounded sequence:

$$\{x_n\}_{n \in \mathbb{N}} \in (0, 1)^{\mathbb{N}} : \left(\forall n \in \mathbb{N} : x_n := \frac{1}{n+2} \right)$$

Then $x_n \rightarrow 0$ yet $0 \notin (0, 1)$. This idea of closedness plays a key role in sequential compactness. □

Definition 1.3. A sequentially compact interval of $\mathbb{R}$ is one for which every sequence has a convergent subsequence that converges to a point within the interval.

The previous Theorem 1.1 leads to a key theorem:

Theorem 1.2. An interval of $\mathbb{R}$ is sequentially compact if and only if it is closed and bounded.

$\Leftarrow$: This direction follows from Sequential Bolzano Weierstrass. If the interval is bounded, then any sequence has a convergent monotone subsequence. Since it is closed, the limit of the sequence, which is an adherent point, belongs in the closure.

$\Rightarrow$: Consider any convergent sequence $\{x_n\}_{n \in \mathbb{N}}$ such that $\forall n \in \mathbb{N} : x_n \in I$. Then by sequential compactness:

$$\exists \{n_k\}_{k \in \mathbb{N}} : x_{n_k} \rightarrow x \wedge x \in I$$

which forces $x_n \rightarrow x$. Thus all convergent sequences converge to points within the set (which by sequential closure) means I is closed. Now assume the interval is not bounded, in which case:

$$\forall r > 0, \forall y \in \mathbb{R} : I \not\subseteq B(y, r)$$

Or equivalently (to bring about the sequential format, we use first countability):

$$\forall n \in \mathbb{N}, \forall y \in \mathbb{R}, \exists x \in I : x \notin B(y, n + 1)$$

Choose some arbitrary $y \in \mathbb{R}$. Then $\forall n \in \mathbb{N}$ choose x_n such that $x_n \notin B(y, n + 1)$, so that:

$$\forall n \in \mathbb{N} : |x_n - y| > n + 1 > 1/2$$

Now assume there existed some z such that some subsequence indexed by $\{n_k\}_{k \in \mathbb{N}}$ converged to z . Then:

$$\forall k \in \mathbb{N} : |x_{n_k} - y| \leq |x_{n_k} - z| + |y - z|$$

$$\Rightarrow \forall k \in \mathbb{N} : ||x_{n_k} - y| - |y - z|| \leq |x_{n_k} - z|$$

Taking limit $k \rightarrow \infty$ we see that $n_k \rightarrow \infty$, thus:

$$||x_{n_k} - y| - |y - z|| \rightarrow 0$$

which is a contradiction because $|x_{n_k} - y| > n_k + 1$ which tells us that $|x_{n_k} - y| \rightarrow \infty$, so $x_{n_k} \not\rightarrow z$ and since z is arbitrary, this holds true for all such $z \in \mathbb{R}$.

Lemma 1.2. For any set $I \subseteq \mathbb{R}$, I is bounded if and only if it is totally bounded (ONLY for $\mathbb{R}$).

Proof. $\Leftarrow$: If I is bounded, then:

$$\exists r > 0, \exists y \in \mathbb{R} : I \subseteq B(y, r) \iff \exists r > 0, \exists y \in \mathbb{R}, \forall x \in I : x \in B(y, r)$$

We aim to show I is totally bounded, which means:

$$\forall \epsilon > 0, \exists x_0, \dots, x_m \in I : I \subseteq \bigcup_{i=0}^m B(x_i, \epsilon)$$

This converse direction is necessarily true; however, the forward direction is not necessarily true in all spaces. Consider the following:

$$M := \max\{|x_i - x_j| : 0 \leq i, j \leq m\}$$

Then, choose some x_i ; so without loss of generality, we choose x_0 :

$$\forall x \in I, \exists x_i : x \in B(x_i, \epsilon) \implies |x - x_0| \leq |x - x_i| + |x_i - x_0| < \epsilon + M$$

$\implies$: Now to prove the forward direction. We have that I is bounded, which means:

$$\exists y \in \mathbb{R}, \exists r > 0 : I \subseteq B(y, r)$$

Now we can show that $B(y, r)$ is totally bounded. Simply consider the uniform partition:

$$\Pi_B := \left\{ (y - r) + \frac{2r}{n}i : 0 \leq i \leq n \right\}$$

whereby:

$$\exists n \in \mathbb{N} : \frac{2r}{n} < \frac{\epsilon}{2}$$

$$\implies \forall \epsilon > 0, \exists \Pi_B : I \subseteq B(y, r) \subseteq \bigcup_{x_i \in \Pi_B} B(x_i, \epsilon/2)$$

Now $\forall x_i \in \Pi_B$ where $B(x_i, \epsilon/2) \cap I \neq \emptyset$, choose x'_i such that:

$$x'_i \in B(x_i, \epsilon/2) \cap I$$

and add it to the partition Π_I . Then we observe that:

$$\forall x \in I, \exists x_i \in \Pi_B : x \in B(x_i, \epsilon/2)$$

$$\implies \exists x'_i \in \Pi_I : |x - x'_i| \leq |x - x_i| + |x_i - x'_i| < \epsilon/2 + \epsilon/2 = \epsilon$$

thus, I is totally bounded such that,

$$\forall \epsilon > 0, \exists \Pi_I : I \subseteq \bigcup_{x'_i \in \Pi_I} B(x'_i, \epsilon)$$

□

Now the main assumption we made here is that every open ball in $\mathbb{R}$ is totally bounded (which we can show via uniform partitions). The rest of the argument is not unique to $\mathbb{R}$. This can give insight into what spaces obey this Heine-Borel compactness property.

NOTE: I will look into this later, it has something to do with finite dimensions/functional analysis.

1.3 Limit Point Compactness

We now discuss an equivalent form of compactness called limit point compactness (which due to the first countability of $\mathbb{R}$) is essentially equivalent to the sequential characterization.

Definition 1.4. A set $K \subseteq \mathbb{R}$ is limit point compact if for all infinite (countably or uncountably) sets $E \subseteq K$, there exists a limit point of E in K .

Theorem 1.3. A set K is limit point compact if and only if it is sequentially compact in $\mathbb{R}$.

Proof. $\implies$: Now consider any sequence $\{x_n\}_{n \in \mathbb{N}} \in K^{\mathbb{N}}$, which is an infinite subset, so by limit point compactness it admits a limit point. Now:

$$\forall n \in \mathbb{N} : \{x_n\}_{n \in \mathbb{N}} \cap B\left(x, \frac{1}{n+1}\right) \neq \emptyset$$

So to construct the converging subsequence (note this requires the Axiom of Choice), we choose:

$$\forall k \in \mathbb{N} : x_{n_k} \in \{x_n\}_{n \in \mathbb{N}} \cap B\left(x, \frac{1}{k+1}\right)$$

such that $\forall k \in \mathbb{N} : n_{k+1} > n_k$.

$\Leftarrow$: Consider any infinite subset of K . Then taking a countable infinite subset of that, we obtain a sequence $\{x_n\}_{n \in \mathbb{N}} \in K^{\mathbb{N}}$ of DISTINCT points.

By sequential compactness, there exists a convergent subsequence converging to a point x . Notice that we do not want one value repeating infinitely many times; otherwise we may not satisfy sequential characterization of limit points.

Now it is possible that x appears as a value, but at most once within the subsequence. Omission of x from this subsequence still results in a convergent subsequence. Assume x appears at some index n_j , then:

$$\forall \epsilon > 0, \exists k_0 \geq 0, \forall k \geq k_0 : |x_{n_k} - x| < \epsilon$$

so if $j \geq k_0$, we still have infinite values other than x from the subsequence within the ϵ -ball around x . This is trivial if $j < k_0$, thus x is an ω -limit point or equivalently a limit point. $\square$

Notice that the $\implies$ direction is not always true in general topological spaces as we used the first countability of metric spaces. The equivalence really stems from the idea of nets/countable nets or sequences. Limit point compactness is identical to sequential compactness in first countable spaces; the only difference being the former describes net-wise behavior, while the latter describes sequential.

But the equivalence fundamentally comes from the equivalent characterization of limit points.